

Property Investment Purchase Checklist — ACT

Due diligence for buying an investment property in a leasehold jurisdiction with its own tax model.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only — not financial, tax or legal advice. Engage a qualified accountant, mortgage broker, and conveyancer before purchasing.

Section 1 — Structuring the Purchase

- ☐ [] **Decide on ownership structure before you buy** — individual, joint, trust, or company each carry different land tax and asset-protection implications.
- ☐ [] **Understand the ACT's distinctive tax model.** The ACT has been running a long-term (multi-decade) program shifting away from stamp duty toward broader-based rates — this is why the ACT could fund the 1 July 2026 stamp duty abolition for first home buyers, and it's worth understanding this direction of travel when thinking about your long-term holding costs as an investor.
- ☐ [] **Know that land tax applies to any ACT residential property that isn't your principal place of residence** — meaning any rental property is generally subject to land tax, in addition to standard rates.
- ☐ [] **Budget for the foreign ownership surcharge if relevant.** The ACT applies a **7%** foreign investor duty surcharge on residential property purchases by foreign persons.
- ☐ [] **Note the first-home-buyer stamp duty exemption doesn't apply to you as an investor** — that reform is specifically for owner-occupiers; investors pay standard conveyance duty rates.
- ☐ [] **Get investment-specific finance pre-approval.**

Section 2 — Due Diligence on the Property Itself

- ☐ [] **Order a building and pest inspection** within your cooling-off window or before auction day.
- ☐ [] **Have a conveyancer or solicitor review the contract before you sign or bid.**
- ☐ [] **Understand you're purchasing leasehold, not freehold, title** — ask your conveyancer whether the specific Crown lease terms have any implications relevant to renting the property out.
- ☐ [] **If buying a unit-titled property, review the owners corporation records thoroughly** — sinking fund health and special levies directly affect your investment returns.
- ☐ [] **Research the local rental market specifically** — vacancy rates, comparable rents, and tenant demand for your target Canberra suburb, noting the significant influence of public service employment patterns on Canberra's rental market.

Section 3 — Setting Up for Compliance From Day One

- ☐ [] **Budget for rates and land tax as ongoing costs** — these apply annually and are a genuine, recurring cost of ACT property investment distinct from a one-off stamp duty bill.
- ☐ [] **Decide on self-management vs. a property manager.**
- ☐ [] **Arrange landlord insurance,** separate from standard building insurance.
- ☐ [] **Engage a quantity surveyor for a tax depreciation schedule** shortly after settlement — see the separate Tax & Depreciation Checklist in this series.

Section 4 — Understanding the Current Tax Environment

- ☐ [] **Be aware Commonwealth CGT settings for investment property are changing,** with reforms affecting the CGT discount generally applying from **1 July 2027** — confirm the finalised current position with your accountant.
- ☐ [] **Get advice on purchase and sale timing relative to this changeover** if your investment horizon spans the 2027 transition.

Quick Reference — ACT Investment Property Snapshot (July 2026)

ITEM	DETAIL
Land tax	Applies to any non-principal-place-of-residence property
Rates	Apply to all ACT properties, funding essential services
Foreign ownership surcharge (duty)	7%
First home buyer stamp duty exemption	Does not apply to investors
Land tenure	Leasehold (Crown lease), not freehold

Land tax and rates settings change with territory budgets — always confirm current figures with the ACT Revenue Office before settling on a purchase strategy.

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